

HISTORY

COMPLETE REVISION GUIDE



Early Humans & Beginning of Civilisation

GRADE 9 • EXAM REVISION

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HISTORY — COMPLETE REVISION GUIDE: Early Humans & Beginning of Civilisation

Authoritative Revision Material for Grade 9 History Prepared by: Senior Educational Strategist & History Curriculum Specialist **Source Authority:** PW Class 9 NEEV & NCERT Curricula

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Chapter 1: The Dawn of Humanity (Biological & Cultural Evolution)

● STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

Students must recognize that human evolution is the baseline for all subsequent historical progress. Examiners frequently test the transition from biological changes (physical traits) to cultural changes (tool-making), as this shift allowed humans to dominate the Quaternary Period. Mastery of this chapter provides the "why" behind human migration and environmental control.

● CHAPTER OVERVIEW

- **The 99% Rule:** Over 99% of human history occurred before the invention of writing.
- **Hominin Definition:** Includes modern humans and all early human-like ancestors.
- **The Tool Differentiator:** Tool-making is the primary "human behaviour" separating us from animals.
- **The Cradle of Life:** Africa is established as the primary homeland of early humans.
- **Out-of-Africa Waves:** Two distinct migrations populated the "Old World."
- **Evolutionary Sequence:** Transition from *Australopithecines* to *Homo sapiens*.

Names & Dates (The Hominin Timeline)

Ancestor, Era / Date, Key Features & Achievements

Australopithecines, 3.3 Million Years Ago, "Southern Primates"; early ancestors in Africa."

Homo habilis, 2–6 Million Years Ago, "The "Handy Man"; first to make chopper stone tools."

Homo erectus, 2 Million Years Ago, "Upright Man"; used hand axes; first to migrate out of Africa."

Neanderthals, "400,000 Years Ago", Settled in Europe and West Asia; adapted to cold.

Homo sapiens, "300,000 Years Ago", Modern humans; developed complex technologies.

Important Terms

- **DEFINITION Hominin:** A group including modern humans and all our early human-like ancestors.
- **DEFINITION Extra-corporal limbs:** Extensions of the human body (tools) helping perform tasks that hands alone cannot.
- **DEFINITION Fossils:** Preserved remains or impressions of ancient plants, animals, or humans turned to stone.
- **DEFINITION Quaternary Period:** The geological period covering the last 26 lakh years, including the present.

How Humans Evolved (Flowchart)

Great Apes -> Chimpanzee/Hominin Split -> Australopithecus (Africa) -> Homo habilis -> Homo erectus -> Neanderthals / Homo sapiens.

Complete Topic Notes

- **Migration Wave 1:** *Homo erectus* left Africa between 2 and 0.5 million years ago, reaching Asia and Europe. They carried stone tools like hand axes and cleavers.
- **Migration Wave 2:** *Homo sapiens* (modern humans) migrated worldwide approximately 125,000 years ago.
- **History Distinction:**
 - *Before Writing:* Dates are approximate; relies on archaeological evidence (artefacts/fossils).
 - *After Writing:* Dates are often fixed; relies on written records and material remains.

One-Minute Revision

1. **Africa** is the "Homeland" of all early human ancestors.
2. **Homo habilis** was the "Handy Man" who created the first tools.
3. **Homo erectus** was the "Upright Man" who first left Africa.
4. **Tools** are "extra-corporal limbs" that define human behavior.
5. **99%** of our history is based on material remains, not written words.

NCERT & Exam Questions

- **Why did early humans leave Africa?** ★ (They migrated in search of resources, following animal movements, and adapting to changing climatic conditions).
- **Compare the sources for history before and after writing.** ★ (Pre-writing relies on **artefacts** and **fossils** ; post-writing includes **written documents** and inscriptions like the **Brahmi script**).

Top 10 Facts

1. *Australis* means "southern" and *pithecus* means "primate."
2. The first stone tools were created 3.3 million years ago.
3. **Olduvai Gorge** (Tanzania/Kenya) is a vital site for *Homo habilis* .
4. *Homo erectus* lived in the Eastern African Rift Valley.

5. **Old World** refers to Africa, Asia, and Europe.
6. Neanderthals lived in Europe until roughly 400,000 years ago.
7. Writing emerged only about 5,000 years ago.
8. Modern humans (*Homo sapiens*) evolved 300,000 years ago.
9. Archaeology uses experiments to see how tools were made.
10. The **Brahmi script** is the ancestor of modern Indian scripts like Hindi. **Connective Tissue:** Tool-making allowed humans to move beyond mere survival, leading to the mastery of stone and the eventual revolution of the Neolithic age.

Chapter 2: The Stone Age & The Neolithic Revolution

● STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

Students must understand the 12,000-year-old trigger: as ice sheets receded, global warming expanded grasslands. This environmental shift forced a "Revolution"—a fundamental change from food **consumption** (hunting) to food **production** (farming).

● CHAPTER OVERVIEW

- **Paleolithic:** Large tools and hunting-gathering.
- **Mesolithic:** Small tools (**Microliths**) and aquatic food.
- **Neolithic:** Polished tools and the birth of the village.

🔑 Important Terms

- **DEFINITION Microliths:** Small, sharp stone tools used for hunting small game and fishing.
- **DEFINITION Neolithic Revolution:** The transition from hunting-gathering to agriculture and settled life.
- **DEFINITION Domestication:** The process of taming plants and animals for human benefit.
- **DEFINITION Pottery:** Clay vessels used to store surplus food and cook grains.

📖 Complete Topic Notes

- **The Stone Age Hierarchy:**
- *Paleolithic:* Simple stone tools; 3.3 million years ago.
- *Mesolithic:* Transition period 12,000 years ago; microliths enabled the first "population explosion."
- *Neolithic:* Polished tools; agriculture began 10,000–3,000 BCE.
- **Regional Agriculture Table:** | Region | Major Crops | | :--- | :--- | | **West Asia** | Wheat and Barley | | **Indian Subcontinent** | Millets and Pulses | | **Ganga Plains** | Rice | | **China** | Millets and Rice |

📍 Important Places

- **Mehrgarh (Pakistan):** Located on the Bolan River (7500 BCE). Features mud-brick houses, granaries, and burials with ornaments.
- **Bhimbetka (MP, India):** Famous for rock art depicting Mesolithic life.

- **Sanganakallu (India):** A key Neolithic site dating to 2000 BCE located on a granite hill.

Connect the Dots

Warmer Climate -> Grassland Expansion -> Availability of Wild Grains -> Microlith Tools -> Settled Village Life.

Cause -> Event -> Effect

Discovery of Agriculture (Cause) -> Village Formation & Surplus (Event) -> Birth of Civilisation (Effect)

Don't Confuse

Paleolithic: Survival against predators with large tools. **Mesolithic:** Aquatic food and fishing with **Microliths**.

Top 10 Facts

1. The Mesolithic began 12,000 years ago with global warming.
2. **Mehrgarh** is the oldest Neolithic site in the Indian subcontinent.
3. Early Indian cattle were called **Zebu**.
4. Domesticated animals included sheep, goats, and cattle.
5. Pottery is the first major use of clay for technology.
6. The Neolithic saw the transition to "Food Production."
7. Villages formed because farmers needed to stay near their crops.
8. **Sanganakallu** proves Neolithic life persisted until 2000 BCE.
9. Agricultural surplus allowed some people to become craftsmen.
10. The Stone Age ended when humans began extracting **Copper**. **Connective Tissue:** Mastering stone and soil provided the surplus food necessary to build the first great urban centers of the Bronze Age.

Chapter 3: The Sindhu–Sarasvatī (Harappan) Civilisation

STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

This is the pinnacle of Bronze Age planning. Students should focus on the Harappan system of standardization—weights, measures, and urban grids—which were the first "Mature" systems in human history.

17 Names & Dates (Harappan Phases)

- **Early Phase:** 3300 BCE (Development of regional pottery styles).
- **Mature Phase:** 2600 BCE – 1900 BCE (Peak urbanism and trade).
- **Late Phase:** 1900 BCE – 1300 BCE (Decline and transition).

Important Terms

- **DEFINITION Pictographic Script:** A writing system using pictures/symbols.

- **DEFINITION Chalcolithic:** The "Copper-Stone" Age (4500 BCE).
- **DEFINITION Steatite Seals:** Stone seals used for trade, featuring animals and script.
- **DEFINITION Sindhu Lipi:** The Harappan script, which remains **undeciphered**.

Complete Topic Notes

- **Standardization:** Harappans used a **binary system** for small weights (1, 2, 4, 8, 16) and a **decimal system** for larger ones.
- **Economy:** Thrived on bead production (carnelian, lapis lazuli), shell work, and copper metallurgy.
- **The Script Mystery:** Unlike the **Brahmi script** (formalized by **Ashoka** and used to write modern Indian languages), Harappan script cannot be read yet.

Important Places

- **Harappa & Mohenjo-Daro:** Major capital cities.
- **Dholavira:** Known for unique water management.
- **Lothal:** A vital port city in Gujarat.
- **Rakhigarhi:** One of the largest urban sites in India.
- **Kunal & Bhirrana:** Important Pre-Harappan/Early Harappan sites.

NCERT Q&A

- **Why were rivers important for this civilisation? ★** (Rivers provided fertile alluvial soil for agriculture, water for consumption, and easy routes for trade and transport).
- **Describe the Harappan weights. ★** (They were cubical stone weights. Small weights followed binary multiples, while large ones used multiples of 10). **Connective Tissue:** While Harappa mastered the rivers of India, other civilisations were doing the same in the "Fertile Crescent" of West Asia.

Chapter 4: The Mesopotamian Civilisation

STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

Students must understand the "Land between Rivers" as the birthplace of the world's first city-states. The key exam takeaway is the transition from Sumerian irrigation to the legal administrative power of Babylon.

17 Names & Dates (Major Dynasties)

Dynasty, Key Feature

Sumerian (3500 BCE), Built first dams and canals; created Cuneiform.

Akkadian (2334 BCE), King Sargon; established the first major empire.

Babylonian (1900 BCE), Hammurabi; created the first written legal code.

Assyrian, Powerful military state in the North.

Important Terms

- **DEFINITION Ziggurat:** A stepped, tower-like temple that served as a city treasury.

- **DEFINITION Cuneiform:** Wedge-shaped marks made on clay tablets using a reed stylus.
- **DEFINITION Fertile Crescent:** A high-potential agricultural region stretching from the Mediterranean to the Persian Gulf.
- **DEFINITION City-State:** An independent city and its surrounding territory.

Complete Topic Notes

- **The Code of Hammurabi:** Crucial development in justice. It replaced the "whims of kings" with a fixed legal system where specific crimes had fixed punishments.
- **Sumerian Science:** Developed a **60-base number system** —the reason we have 60 minutes in an hour and 360 degrees in a circle.
- **Specific Sites:** **Ur, Uruk, Akkad, and Babylon** were the heart of this civilisation.

Cause -> Event -> Effect

Control of Tigris/Euphrates (Cause) -> Irrigation/Canals (Event) -> Food Surplus & Urban Growth (Effect)

One-Minute Revision

1. **Mesopotamia** means "land in between" the Tigris and Euphrates.
2. **Cuneiform** is the wedge-shaped writing system of the Sumerians.
3. **King Sargon** created the world's first empire.
4. **Ziggurats** were temples that also functioned as banks/treasuries.
5. **Hammurabi** gave the world its first written laws.

Chapter 5: The Egyptian Civilisation

STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

Egypt is the "Gift of the Nile." Students should analyze how the predictable Nile floods created a social hierarchy so stable it lasted thousands of years, focused on the afterlife and royal authority.

17 Names & Dates

- Developed a 365-day calendar based on the Nile's cycle.
- **Cleopatra:** The last and most famous Queen of Egypt.

Important Terms

- **DEFINITION Hieroglyphics:** The "sacred" pictographic script of Egypt.
- **DEFINITION Pharaoh:** The absolute ruler of Egypt, viewed as a god-king.
- **DEFINITION Papyrus:** Paper-like material made from the papyrus plant.
- **DEFINITION Mummification:** The process of preserving a body for the afterlife.
- **DEFINITION Mastaba:** A rectangular burial structure; the ancestor of the pyramid.

Complete Topic Notes

- **The Rosetta Stone:** Discovered in 1799; contained text in three scripts, allowing scholars like **Jean-François Champollion** to finally decipher Hieroglyphics.
- **The Sed Festival:** A major celebration held after a Pharaoh had ruled for **30 years** to rejuvenate their power.
- **The Afterlife:** Egyptians believed in the **"Ka"** (a spiritual double). This led to the complex mummification process to preserve the body for the spirit.

Connect the Dots

Nile Flood -> Rich Silt (Kemet) -> Agricultural Surplus -> Pharaoh Power -> Pyramid Construction.

NCERT Q&A

- **Why was the Nile important?** ★ (The Nile provided the "Kemet"—rich black silt—which made farming possible in the desert. It also dictated the three-season calendar).
- **Describe the process of mummification.** ★ (Internal organs were removed, the body was dried using **natron**, treated with oils, and wrapped in linen to preserve it for the "Ka").

Chapter 6: The Chinese Civilisation

STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

The Huang He (Yellow River) fostered a civilisation known for **continuity**. While other ancient societies collapsed, China's bureaucratic and imperial systems survived through the "Mandate of Heaven."

17 Names & Dates (The Dynastic Cycle)

- **Shang (1600 BCE):** Bronze Age beginnings; used **Oracle Bones**.
- **Zhou:** Longest-lasting dynasty; established the "Mandate of Heaven."
- **Qin (Ch'in):** The first **Imperial Dynasty** that **Unified China**. The name "China" comes from "Qin."
- **Han:** Developed the **Silk Route** and the Civil Service system.

Exam Keywords

- **Unified China:** Achievement of the Qin Dynasty.
- **Silk Route:** Long-distance trade network connecting China to the West.
- **Qin Dynasty:** The origin of China's name and first imperial bureaucracy.

Important Terms

-  **DEFINITION Logo-graphic Script:** A writing system where characters represent whole words or meanings.

- **DEFINITION Oracle Bones:** Animal bones/shells used to predict the future and record history.
- **DEFINITION Jade:** A precious stone valued more than gold in ancient China.

Complete Topic Notes

- **Innovation:** China was the first to use **paper currency** and developed the world's first **Civil Service Examinations** (merit-based government).
- **The Great Wall:** Constructed over 2,000 years to protect against nomadic raids.
- **Silk:** A secret technology for centuries; became China's most valuable export.

Don't Confuse

Script Type, Civilisation, Visual Style
 Cuneiform, Mesopotamian, Wedge-shaped marks
 Hieroglyphics, Egyptian, Sacred pictures/symbols
 Logo-graphic, Chinese, Characters for whole words
 Pictographic, Harappan, Animal/Geometric motifs

7. Final Exam Revision Master-Section

Comparative Table of Civilisations

Feature, Harappan, Mesopotamian, Egyptian, Chinese
 Rivers, Sindhu & Sarasvatī, Tigris & Euphrates, Nile, Huang He & Yangtze
 Script, Pictographic (Undeciphered), Cuneiform (Wedge), Hieroglyphics, Logo-graphic
 Main Structure, Citadel & Granary, Ziggurat (Temple), Pyramid & Mastaba, Great Wall
 Key Metals, Bronze & Copper, Bronze, Bronze, Bronze & Iron
 Social Status, Standardized Weights, Fixed Justice (Code), High Rights for Women, Mandate of Heaven

The "Big Picture" Timeline

- **3.3 Million Years Ago:** Earliest stone tools; human behavior begins.
- **2 Million Years Ago:** *Homo erectus* leaves Africa (Wave 1).
- **300,000 Years Ago:** *Homo sapiens* evolve in Africa.
- **125,000 Years Ago:** *Homo sapiens* migrate globally (Wave 2).
- **12,000 Years Ago:** Climate warms; Mesolithic microliths appear.
- **7500 BCE:** Agriculture at **Mehrgarh**.
- **3300 BCE:** Bronze Age begins; Early Harappan phase.
- **2600 BCE:** Mature Harappan Urbanism peak.
- **1300 BCE:** End of the Late Harappan phase.

Answer Writing Tips

1. **Use Cause-Effect Boxes:** For questions on "Revolutions," show the logic: *Warmer Climate -> Grasslands -> Farming*.
2. **Highlight Key Sites:** Use names like **Attirampakkam** (Palaeolithic) or **Sanganakallu** (Neolithic) to gain extra marks.

3. **Define Terms Exactly:** Use source definitions. For example, "Tools are **extra-corporal limbs** " shows deep understanding.